

01

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The philosophical question of truth remains separate from the political value of coexistence.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The philosophical question of truth remains separate from the political value of coexistence.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Fact: In April 2026, the United Nations in India reported that UNAOC High Representative Miguel Ángel Moratinos highlighted India's historical religious pluralism and interfaith traditions during a Delhi visit. □□ Inference: Public praise of interfaith harmony supports pluralism as an ethic of engagement, but it does not establish Hick's metaphysical claim that rival religions are equally valid responses to one Real.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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ANSWER LINE: □ Fact: In April 2026, the United Nations in India reported that UNAOC High Representative Miguel Ángel Moratinos highlighted India's historical religious pluralism and interfaith traditions during a Delhi visit. □□ Inference: Public praise of interfaith harmony supports pluralism as an ethic of engagement, but it does not establish Hick's metaphysical claim that rival religions are equally valid responses to one Real.

02

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH: CORE DISTINCTIONS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The worry (2022): "unquestionable acceptance of only one Absolute Truth will inevitably result in religious exclusivism" → and exclusivism breeds conflict/intolerance. □ If "absolute truth" = my religion's propositions are the sole truth → yes, tends to exclusivism.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

[Vedantic] "Vedantic religious pluralism & Vivekananda's Universal Religion vs conflicting truth-claims." (2025, 20m) → §2. [Absolute truth] "'One Absolute Truth → religious exclusivism.' Discuss." (2022) → §3. [Pluralism-conflict] "Does pluralism invite inter-religious conflict & destroy religion's truth?" (2023) → §3. [Notion] "Notion of absolute truth in religion." (2024) → §3. [Tolerance] "Importance of religious tolerance in a multicultural pluralistic society." (2020, 10m) → §9.6 — Forst's ladder; Aśoka RE XII; Vivekananda's acceptance-not-tolerance. [Freedom] "Is religious freedom possible in a multireligious society?" (2021, 10m) → §9.7 — principled distance + internal minorities. [Conflict] "Is the History of Religions the History of Conflicts?" (2020, 10m) → §9.8 — cause/marker/mobiliser/legitimiser. [Unifier] "Is religion a uniting force for humanity in the globalizing world?" (2019, 10m) → §9.9 — three conditions. [E vs P] "Central problem between religious pluralists and exclusivists." (2019, 20m) → §9.1 + §9.11 + §9.10 (deep disagreement). [Truth is one] "'Truth is one, yet people perceive differently' — evaluate in the Indian context." (2018, 15m) → §2 + RV 1.164.46 discipline + anekāntavāda.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Master verdict: Pluralism is strongest when it combines realism about an Absolute with fallibilism about finite access, while openly admitting that some first-order truth-claims remain contradictory.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Commitment to absolute truth does not entail epistemic absolutism: reality may be determinate even when finite religious formulations remain partial and corrigible.

ANSWER LINE: Exclusivism reserves decisive truth or salvation for one tradition, inclusivism admits truth elsewhere under one fulfilment, and pluralism treats multiple traditions as independently valid responses to ultimate reality.